

Episode 31: Once Upon a Time... (23) *Saint Seiya* Part 10 – Theatrical *Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth* – Preview Cuts and "Light, Shadow, and Colour"

Last weekend I mowed the lawn at my parents' house. Since my father passed away in spring, including his illness period, it was the first lawn mowing in about a year. Oh man, it had grown completely wild - more like "grass cutting" than "lawn mowing."

I tried using a rechargeable lawn mower I bought online, but the main machine's charging took over ten hours - heartbreaking (cries). I ended up using the handheld clipper-like device that came as a bonus (?) to buzz-cut everything.

Man, this was fun! It cut amazingly well! Plus since it was so overgrown, I could cut huge swaths and it visibly became clean - quite satisfying (laughs). Ah, barbers cutting long hair must feel this kind of enjoyment (laughs).

Well, the battery dying after cutting about half the lawn was predictable (laughs). The rest carries over to next time.

And getting muscle soreness the next day was also predictable (laughs).

Well then.

After successfully finishing colour direction meetings for theatrical "*Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth*", main episode cuts finally came to me. First, the preview edition advance batch.

Toei Doga's theatrical work method doesn't wait for complete storyboards - as soon as storyboards finish, animation meetings proceed and orders go to key animators. So what comes up first are the initial cuts that finished animation meetings early. Well, for initial previews, there's no need to use climax cuts - rather, main story introduction

"atmosphere" cuts are stacked for previews. This time too, we made previews centred on opening scenes of Abel (アベル) and Gold Saints appearing. Incidentally, back then preview cut selection and direction were assistant director jobs. Now they often just hand materials to preview editing companies from the start.

Though preview cuts, they're basically main episode cuts. But with the "tacit understanding" that "since we're shooting once first anyway," previews become pre-main story tests for various processing.

Now you can do quick test shots on PC, but back then was the cel painting + film photography era. Preparing materials, shooting, sending to labs for development - quite an effort. Moreover, since movies use 35mm film rather than TV series' 16mm film, development costs were enormously high - even brief shooting cost tremendous money. So previews could, in a sense, be openly used for test photography.

Still, even with test photography positioning and "tacit understanding," these are films shown to theatres audiences, so the finished product is naturally a complete screen. Made premised on main episode use with "retake if no good." If this turns out perfectly OK, there's no need to reshoot for main episodes.

But actually trying it, various departments come up with "want to do it a bit more like this" or "want to change this here." So ultimately, over half the preview cuts became "reshoot for main episode," mainly adding/changing light-related processing. And some colour direction also changed.

"Saori-san, let's change the atmosphere a bit after all?" said Director Yamauchi (山内). He apparently wanted to tinker with Saori-san's scenes wearing the same clothes used on TV. However, we couldn't significantly alter main characters' hair or eye colours, and costumes were already progressing with current main character settings for quite a few cuts. "Well then..." so we decided to keep the design as-is and tinker with clothing colours.

So Saori-san's skirt, which was the same pink as the TV series in previews, became blue in the theatrical main story. However, this would later remain as a major flaw...

So previews finished and we plunged into the main story. This story, after arriving at the Sanctuary (サンクチュアリ), covers the short time from day to night. So we decided to properly handle time passage through art and "colour." The flow of day → early evening → sunset → night would be created with cels matching backgrounds precisely.

As I wrote before, TV series *Saint Seiya* usually used normal colour direction for most scenes regardless of day/night. So we decided to do the colour changes we'd tried in the previous theatrical *The Heated Battle of the Gods* much more finely throughout the entire work.

The basic thinking was "the light and shadow colours of that space naturally apply to characters too." Sunlight pours down universally on background buildings, ground, and space. That light's colour tones determine the space's colour tones. Whether blazing summer light, soft light through clouds, western sun, or morning sun. Not just sun - starlight, moonlight, illumination, lightning are the same. Or spaces where sun has set and light no longer reaches, night darkness, even hard-to-reach underwater spaces have their basic light and shadow colour tones. So characters standing there receive the same light, create the same shadows, and are influenced by that space's colour tones.

So first we match character brightness to the necessary spatial brightness, then pick up spatial (background) colour tones and add them to character colours. The degree here is crucial. If brightness and colour tones exactly match the background, characters assimilate with backgrounds and necessary acting becomes invisible. If we thought truly realistically, especially on starlit nights, cels and backgrounds assimilating would look correct, but that wouldn't work as screen composition. Conversely, if characters are too strong, acting becomes hollow and disappointing.

How much to match, how much to show. The degree of "making character presence and acting stand out" depends on work tendencies, but this "*Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth*" became my first work in a sense for determining that "degree."

This remains my theme today.

Now digital colouring helps as a weapon, so that "degree" can aim for almost satisfying balance, but back then was still the cel paint era. Moreover, the desperately intermediate-colour and low-saturation-lacking STAC colours, Toei colour chart world. Plus the colour count itself was overwhelmingly small. I spent every day and night repeatedly test-painting to explore what combinations would show the targeted colour tones.

Looking back now, I think I used imagination more richly to create colours back then.

(07.10.09)